Mark Nicholas, the cricket commentator and former Hampshire captain, was interviewing the captains at the toss before the quarterfinal at the SCG and, off camera, he said he thought I looked nervous. I smiled. He was mistaken. In fact, given the well-documented history, I felt amazingly calm and confident. The warm-up had gone exceptionally well, and I sensed we were going to deliver a high-quality performance at the right time.

As it turned out, we played an almost perfect game.

The Sri Lankans won the toss and batted, but were four for two in the fifth over. Kumar Sangakkara and Lahiru Thirimanne threatened to stage a recovery but both fell in their 40s, and what looked a skilful and dangerous batting team were dismissed for only 133 before the end of the 38th over. Our seamers created the pressure at the top of the order, and spinners Imran and JP took four and three wickets respectively.

We reached the target for the loss of only one wicket, with Quinton de Kock scoring a brisk and unbeaten 78 in 57 balls, guiding us to victory with an almost unbelievable 32 overs to spare.

Once again with perfect timing, the little green book landed in the hands of our young, massively talented wicketkeeper and opening batsman, and Quinton wrote that evening: 'We just smashed the Sri Lankans at the SCG. What a great win it was. Weirdly, it was our spin twins (Immy and JP) who just went right through them, with JP taking his first ever hat-trick. After the game, we enjoyed our night to end a memorable day.'

So we made the three-hour flight across the Tasman Sea for the fifth time in the tournament. Having started our campaign in New Zealand, flown to Australia, back to New Zealand, then to Australia for the quarterfinal, we headed back to Auckland to play New Zealand in the semifinal at Eden Park.

The Proteas team for the quarterfinal had been Amla, De Kock, Du Plessis, Rossouw, De Villiers, Miller, Duminy, Steyn, Abbott, Morkel and Tahir, which meant it had included three so-called players of colour as